
Sorry, Boy George. AI can't even make bad art

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Writing something is a bit like polishing rocks. You start with an ugly hunk of something, a phrase or an idea you've tripped over. It rattles against the hard edges of your brain until it gets polished and smooth. Moving the rock through finer and finer grits is time-consuming, strenuous and not always rewarding. Sometimes, the lump becomes a slightly smaller and shinier lump, marginally less ugly than it was on the ground. But like exercise and tough conversations, the process is the point. You feel better for having gone through the ritual yourself.

Boy George didn't get the memo.

The former Culture Club frontman, whose voice adorned New Wave pop hits like "Karma Chameleon" and "Do You Really Want to Hurt Me" in the 1980s, had [artificial intelligence](#) spew out an unfortunate reggae song last week that turned out to be a statement of support for Israel's ongoing war in Gaza. "You say genocide, I say war," the song, titled "[We Will Dance Again.](#)" starts, and the lyrics seem to revel in the ugliness of the ongoing violence in Gaza. The tens of thousands of Palestinian deaths, the song claims, are "what the military's for."

Obvious AI tells throughout this track make clear that Boy George hasn't just gotten lazy, he's also lost the quality of discernment. The song's meter is odd, and its lines are overstuffed. There are no interesting choices, no glimpses of an artist's vision. It's a hollow provocation over a royalty-free riddim.

Against that backdrop, a song defending and celebrating the Israeli military is nasty work, no matter who made it. The fact that no one made it, that it's the creation of a machine that hallucinates in exchange for electricity, only intensifies the sick, empty feeling the track leaves behind.

Since Hamas militants attacked Israeli military installations and civilians on October 7, 2023, the ensuing war in Gaza has left [more than 73,000 Palestinians dead](#). The United Nations has called Israel's campaign a genocide. The International Criminal Court has issued an arrest warrant for Benjamin Netanyahu, accusing the Israeli prime minister of crimes against humanity. Attacks on Gaza continue despite a ceasefire deal. Against that backdrop, a song defending and celebrating the Israeli military is nasty work, no matter who made it. The fact that *no one* made it, that it's the creation of a machine that hallucinates in exchange for electricity, only intensifies the sick, empty feeling the track leaves behind.

The track's release has been a disaster for George. He split acrimoniously from Tony Pontius, the long-time manager of his record label BGP, [because of Pontius' refusal](#) to release the song. A planned role as King Herod in a production of "Jesus Christ Superstar" was put on ice. Spotify pulled the track down for violating its restrictions around AI-generated music. Bandcamp followed soon thereafter. Boy George has dug in his heels in recent days, calling the platforms a "bunch of c**ts" as part of a steady stream of Instagram posts. His doggedness would be almost admirable, if "We Will Dance Again" wasn't so lazy.

In releasing the track, Boy George presumably wanted to turn heads, to make a statement. But he didn't want to do any work. He didn't want to record multiple vocal takes of lines he supposedly wrote and believes in. He didn't want to arrange actual instruments to better emphasize his lyrics and pro-war stance. He didn't want to mix the track carefully to refine his statement. He could have

made something that shimmers, a piece of true pop that expresses repellent ideals. It wouldn't have been the first.

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Merle Haggard's iconoclastic "[Okie From Muskogee](#)" is considered a country classic, even though the sentiment is about as far from mainstream American thought in 2026 as can be imagined. When even right-wing commentators are pushing microdosing as a path to self-betterment, his disparaging remarks about longhairs taking LSD come off as impossibly square. But you can hear the heart in Haggard's leathery vocals, buoyed by the sweet harmonies of his backing band. Haggard waffled over the years on whether the anti-hippie hardliner anthem was a satire of the crew cut set or a genuine tribute to his conservative father. Either way, Haggard sounds like he believes what he's saying, regardless of whether that's true, because of the time and effort he spent working out the song.

With 2013's "Blurred Lines," Robin Thicke and Pharrell set out to make a groovy single in the vein of Marvin Gaye. Though the song has been relegated to the dustbin following a widespread critical backlash and later [allegations of sexual assault](#) against Thicke by model and actress Emily Ratajowski, who appeared in the song's video, they were extremely successful. The song itself, creepiness aside, is a Swiss watch of a partystarter. Pharrell's ad-libs and inserts interrupting the groove at perfect intervals to wake up the dancefloor. They arguably did too good a job recreating the shuffling, glass-clinking percussion of 1970s cocktail party classics, as they lost almost everything they'd made from the song in a subsequent — and successful — [lawsuit from Gaye's estate](#).

"We Will Dance Again" does none of that. It warrants no qualifiers, no deeper thought, because Boy George clearly didn't think too hard about it himself before spitting it out into the world. He asked a machine to build him a song to support what many consider to be an ongoing genocide. When it offered him half a song, he said, "Good enough" — without even bothering to run it through a few rounds of polishing. I regret to inform you that, in 2026, Boy George won't even tumble for us.

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